

Nantucket Family Adventure: August 3rd – August 6th

1. Trip Overview & Essential Logistics

As your concierge, I have curated this itinerary to balance the island's sophisticated charm with the practical needs of a family traveling with a four-year-old. The journey from Westport, CT, begins with a strategic drive to Hyannis to catch the ferry.

Travel Timeline

Date, Event, Time

August 3rd, "Depart Westport, CT (Allow 4 hours for traffic/bridges)", 7:00 AM

, Arrive in Hyannis (Parking & Ferry Check-in), 11:00 AM

, Board Traditional Ferry, 12:00 PM

, Arrival in Nantucket, 2:15 PM

August 6th, Board Traditional Ferry, 2:15 PM

, Arrival in Hyannis, 4:30 PM

, "Arrival back in Westport, CT", 8:30 PM

The Ferry Crossing

For this adventure, I explicitly recommend the **Traditional Ferry**. While the high-speed options exist, the 2 hour and 15 minute traditional crossing offers a quintessential, scenic introduction to the harbor that allows the family to decompress before docking. To ensure a stress-free start, you must arrive at the Hyannis dock by 11:00 AM to navigate parking and ticketing.

Island Transportation: The WAVE

Nantucket's "WAVE" bus system is the most efficient way to traverse the island without the headache of cobblestone parking. Supported by MassDOT, all routes on the WAVE are **COMPLETELY FREE** for all riders through the end of 2026. This includes the Jetties, Madaket, and Siasconset routes utilized in this itinerary.

- **Official Route Map:** [Download the WAVE Map](#)
- **Wave On-Demand:** For a more private experience, use the "Wave On-Demand" app (similar to a rideshare). **Expert Note:** This service only operates within specific **service zones**; be sure to check the app for coverage before booking.

2. Day 1: Arrival & Harbor Exploration (Monday, August 3rd)

Afternoon: Check-in and Children's Beach

Upon docking at 2:15 PM, head directly to **The Cottages at Boat Basin** to drop your bags. Once settled, a short walk brings you to **Children's Beach** (15 & 40 Harbor Way).

- **Pro Tip for Parents:** While the paved walkway is ADA-accessible, please be aware there is a **small initial incline** near the entrance that can be tricky with a heavy stroller.
- **Kid-Friendly Features:**

- **Playground:** My top recommendation for the little one is the sensory play area on the smaller structure, where they can trace the touchable map of the United States.
- **Calm Waters:** Because this beach is nestled within the harbor, the water remains tranquil—perfect for a four-year-old to splash safely.
- **Facilities:** The area features accessible restrooms and an adjacent cafe for quick refreshments.

Evening: Dinner and The "Quintessential Stroll"

- **5:30 PM:** Your first island meal is at **or, The Whale** (38 Main St), a vibrant bistro with a beautiful patio. View their [current menu here](#).
- **7:00 PM:** The quintessential Nantucket evening concludes with a walk up historic Main Street to **The Juice Bar** (12 Broad St). The line moves fast, and the homemade ice cream is an absolute must-do for your first night.

3. Day 2: Beaches, Whales & West End Sunsets (Tuesday, August 4th)

Morning: Jetties Beach

Board the WAVE (Jetties Beach Route) for a morning at **Jetties Beach**. This is a family favorite for its expansive playground and full-service restrooms. Enjoy a casual lunch with your toes in the sand at **The Sandbar at Jetties**.

Afternoon: The Whaling Museum (13 Broad St)

After the sun, retreat to the **Whaling Museum**. This is a strategic afternoon stop because the entire facility is **fully air-conditioned**, providing a vital break from the August heat.

- **Don't Miss:** The 46-foot sperm whale skeleton and the rooftop deck, which offers the best panoramic views of the harbor.
- **For the 4-Year-Old:** Head to the **Discovery Center** play space. If you time it right, the "Family Connections Tour" includes tactile elements and ends with a take-home craft activity in the center.

Evening: Millie's & Madaket Magic

- **The Strategy:** Take the WAVE (Madaket Route) to the West End for dinner at **Millie's** (326 Madaket Rd). As they do not take reservations, I suggest arriving by 5:00 PM.
- **Dining Highlights:** Order the **"Kids Turkey"** (turkey, cheese, and mayo) or the **"Taco Box"** for the table. If the wait is prohibitive, grab takeout and head to the sand.
- **Sunset:** Walk over to **Madaket Beach** for the island's most famous sunset before catching the bus back to town.

4. Day 3: 'Sconset Beauty & The Strategic Picnic (Wednesday, August 5th)

Morning: Siasconset Exploration

Take the WAVE (Siasconset Route) to the East End, a village that feels frozen in time.

- **Activity:** Walk the **'Sconset Bluff Walk**.

- **Expert Concierge Tip:** This path is stunningly beautiful but very narrow and sits close to the cottage edges. Keep a firm hand on your four-year-old at all times here.
- **Lunch:** Visit **Sconset Market** (4 Main St) for sandwiches. Be sure to pick up their "**famous Sconset cookies**" and what many locals consider "**Nantucket's best brownie**" for an afternoon treat.

Evening: "The Long Wednesday Strategy"

This is your secret weapon for the trip. At **6:00 PM**, pick up "Turkey Terrific" sandwiches (the island's most famous sandwich) or kids' meals from **Provisions** (3 Harbor Square). **The Parenting Win:** Feed the kids their "main" dinner during a picnic on the **Boat Basin docks** while they watch the massive yachts move in and out. By letting them eat early in an engaging environment, you ensure they are well-fed and relaxed before your late reservation.

Late Night: The Nautilus

- **9:45 PM:** Dinner at **The Nautilus**.
- **The Nibble:** Since the children already had their "Turkey Terrific" picnic, they can simply join you for "fancy snacks." I recommend ordering the **dumplings and bao** for them to nibble on while you enjoy the full culinary experience.

5. Day 4: Historic Wharfs & Departure (Thursday, August 6th)

Morning: Old South Wharf

Take a final, slow stroll through **Old South Wharf**. This is the perfect time for a classic photo op at the "**Compass Rose**" painted on the ground—a landmark every specialist knows is a required shot for the family album.

Lunch: A Farewell Toast

- **11:30 AM:** Enjoy a final farewell meal at the historic **Brotherhood of the Thieves**.

Final Logistics

Ensure you are at the docks by **1:30 PM** for the **2:15 PM** ferry departure. Upon arrival in Hyannis at 4:30 PM, prepare for the approximately 4-hour drive back to Westport, arriving home around 8:30 PM.

6. Nantucket Directory (Addresses & Quick Links)

Dining & Provisions

- **or, The Whale:** 38 Main Street | otwnantucket.com
- **The Juice Bar:** 12 Broad Street | ackjuicebar.com
- **Millie's (Madaket):** 326 Madaket Road | milliesnantucket.com
- **Provisions:** 3 Harbor Square | provisions-nantucket.com
- **Sconset Market:** 4 Main Street, Siasconset | sconsetmarket.com
- **The Nautilus:** 12 Cambridge Street | nautilusnantucket.com

- **Brotherhood of the Thieves:** 23 Broad Street | brotherhoodofthieves.com
- **The Sandbar at Jetties:** 4 Bathing Beach Road

Attractions & Landmarks

- **Whaling Museum:** 13 Broad Street | nha.org
- **Children's Beach:** 15 Harbor Way (Beach) & 40 Harbor Way (Playground)
- **The Cottages at Boat Basin:** 24 Old South Wharf
- **NRTA WAVE Bus:** [Official Website & Route Map](#)